Journal of Rural Studies 28 (2012) 208–217

Contents lists available at SciVerse ScienceDirect

Journal of Rural Studies

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jrurstud

Relational rurals: Some thoughts on relating things and theory in rural studies

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Keywords:
Relational space
Countertopography
Globalization
Theory
Place

A B S T R A C T

This paper considers how shifts within the social sciences towards conceptualising spatiality in relational terms have unfolded in rural studies in particular ways over the past decade or so. A period in which networks, connections, flows and mobility have all established themselves as compelling conceptual frames for research, the rural has increasingly been recast in relational terms as a multi-authored and multi-faceted space, constituted through local-global interconnections and their place specific, sometimes contested, manifestations. In this way, the multiple meanings of the rural continues to be a focus of critical concern, as are the implications 'of' and 'in' rural spaces for some of the major issues currently being faced by governments and citizens around the world; including climate change and food security. Apprehending the complexity of the rural in these terms, we argue, requires not only *thinking* space relationally, but at the same time *being* epistemologically relational or theoretically pluralist. That is, recognising the co-constituent production of rural space through material *and* discursive phenomenon, processes and practices, and thus the value of existing theoretical resources (social constructionism, political and economic materialism) in relation with the critical and rigorous appraisal of 'new' concepts and ideas to better comprehend rural space in its multidimensional complexity and particularity. To this end, we identify Cindi Katz's notion of 'countertopography' as a promising conceptual and methodological addition to the rural scholar's toolkit insofar as it attends to a politics of location and differentation in relation to global processes. We conclude our discussion by sketching out possible objects of countertopographical analysis for understanding ongoing processes of change in rural space(s).

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1. Introduction

Woods (2011a) notes an increasing recognition of relations and their significance in accounts of the rural. This trend has progressed in dialogue with the widespread adoption of a relational spatial ontology within human geography (and more broadly) over the past decade or so. This 'relational' understanding is premised on the shift from a structuralist 'topography' of Euclidean spatiality (height, depth, size, proximity) to a 'topological' geography of space–time relations and practices (see Massey, 2005). As such, it emphasises:

> The significance of networks, connections, flows and mobilities in constituting space and place and the social, economic, cultural and political forms and processes associated with them (…) It collapses the dualisms of nature and society and human and non-human, adopting an agnostic position regarding all entities, human and non-human as equal components within a network. (Woods, 2011a, pp. 40–41)

As with preceding 'turns' which have taken place across the geographic discipline (and here we include the 'cultural', 'scalar' and 'mobility' variety) the ascendency of relational thinking can only be situated within the context of ongoing re-conceptualizations of space and place. As such, the point in time at which spaces of relation became a major focus for human geographers is far from clear, as are the exact parameters of constituent debates. What is certain, however, is the huge importance of 'thinking space relationally' and the value of this work in unsettling dominant spatial imaginaries (Jones, 2009). As a consequence, our understandings of spatiality have become less constrained by bounded (territory) or hierarchal (scalar) structural forms, and our spatial analyses have become more attentive to connectivity in all its forms.

'Being relational' implies not only an ontological re-envisaging of space 'but also a shift in practise and method' (Boggs and Rantisi, 2003, p. 115), and within rural studies the arrival of

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doi:10.1016/j.jrurstud.2012.01.011

relational thinking has prompted a period of stock-taking and introspection (Woods, 2009b). This has in turn precipitated recognition of the need to embrace new theoretical directions, methodological imperatives and research trajectories. These trajectories include the critical reassertion of Actor-Network Theory, driven foreword by Murdoch (1997, 2000, 2003, 2006) and others (including Donaldson et al., 2002; Enticott, 2003), whose contributions demonstrate the manner in which (rural) orders of human and non-human assemblages are accomplished across time and space, and a complementary concern with the embodied practice and performance of rurality across various sociospatial contexts (Edensor, 2006; Little and Leyshon, 2003). This, however, has not been to the extent of abandoning representation as a key component in the production of rural space. Rather, efforts to understand how different communities define and 'know' the rural are set to become more nuanced, and here we include (following Woods, 2011a) recent work on political/policy accounts of rurality (e.g. Marsden and Sonnino, 2008; Potter and Tilzey, 2005), media constructions of the countryside (e.g. Burnett and Danson, 2004; Horton, 2008) and lay discourses, which are grounded in everyday practise and patterns of cultural exchange (Munkejord, 2006; van Dam et al., 2002).

Thus if we are to talk in terms of a 'relational turn' in rural studies, we argue this has involved an increasing recognition of the intertwined and co-constituent production of rural space through material *and* discursive phenomenon, processes and practices. This is evident through the ongoing development of what we term *relational rural epistemologies*; that is, approaches which are seeking to ground examination of the 'reproduction of rural discourses' within and through the 'material dimension of the rural condition that have a real impact on the experiences of people living, working and playing in rural space' (Woods, 2009b, p. 851). On this premise, this paper is concerned with sketching out the emergence and advancement of a range of rural epistemologies which have (either implicitly or tacitly) grappled with the ontological condition of relational space, and with the connections and digressions between these conceptual frameworks. In so doing, we take a broadly (though not strictly) chronological approach, identifying the development of key arguments and key texts.

Our starting point is the social production of rural space, and that body of work which has characterised rurality as a patchwork derived through the differentiated ways in which global political economic tendencies work through, come up against, and shape the conditions of locally embedded actors. Following a line of critique which identified this 'differentiated countryside' model as being overly determinant of the way rural space is and could be shaped, we subsequently focus on the impacts and implications of postmodern and poststructural debates in rural studies. Reflecting firstly on the impact of network sociology among scholars of the rural, and as a counter-point the growing appreciation of Lefebvre's spatial 'trialectic' for considering the co-constitutive relations between representational, material and lived rurals, these (complimentary) spatial frameworks are shown as being integral to current concerns with the 'global countryside'.

A concept which brings together political economy, social discourse and embodied rural performance, the global countryside (Woods, 2007) is intentionally theoretically pluralistic and is, we argue, concomitant with the enhanced desire for 'minor theory' in the social sciences. A model developed by Katz (1996) and more recently taken forward in a rural context by Cloke (2006), minor theory embraces the critical perspectives of historical materialism, feminism and other regimes of knowing at once, as well as the collective practical basis of analysis that these perspectives require. As such, minor theory is a prompt for seeing and being relational, and, sensitive to the need for more substantial engagement with how we *do* relational rural studies, we subsequently identify Cindi Katz's (2001) notion of 'countertopography' as a useful means to this end. By way of demonstrating the value of this approach, we conclude our discussion by sketching out some possible objects of countertopographical analysis for understanding ongoing processes of change in rural space(s).

2. The social production of rural space

The antecedents of the current turn to 'thinking space relationally' in human geography lie with the re-thinking of space firstly as *relative* as opposed to *absolute*, and then later as *relational*, across the social sciences more broadly (for a recent overview see Jones, 2009, 2010). In this vein space has increasingly been presented as the constantly unfolding product of flows and networks, alongside and in coevality with the more traditional concern of territory. The result, argues Ash Amin, is:

> '[N]o simple displacement of the local by the global, of place by space, of history by simultaneity and flow, of small by big scale, or of the proximate by the remote. Instead it is a subtle folding together of the distant and the proximate, the virtual and the material, presence and absence, flow and stasis, into which location—a place on the map—has come to be relationally and topologically defined' (Amin, 2007, p. 103)

Making sense of this conceptual shift, notes Amin is not an easy task; but it is a process which is ongoing across the social sciences. In particular, the notion of relational space and what it means for our inquires has been hotly contested in the broad and interrelated areas of economic and political geography (e.g. Bathelt and Glückler, 2003; Jones, 2009; MacLeod, 2001; Massey, 2004; Sunley, 2008; Yeung, 2005) in recent times. The genesis of these debates, however, can (and indeed should) be set within a much longer critical timeframe.

The shift from an absolute conception of space as a container for objects and processes, to one where the spatial relations between objects and events—and thereby relative to them—were of significance, was understood to require a more scientific mode of capture and analysis. Yet the burgeoning project of spatial science sat unhappily with many human geographers (Olsson, 1974; Sack, 1974) who instead moved away from totalising accounts of space towards seeking to apprehend the particular spatiality of capitalist production in relation to its contingent social practices (Harvey, 1973, 1982; Soja, 1989). In developing a new spatial reading of Historical Materialism, both Harvey and Soja were to be strongly influenced by the writings of Henri Lefebvre (1974/1991) in terms of recognizing how space is actively produced by human beings to achieve their various social interests. Specifically, Lefebvre drew attention to space as now 'intrinsically linked with capitalism and exchange, rather than being somehow relatively independent of society's mode of production' (Halfacree, 2006, p. 49).[2] A relational perspective on space was similarly emerging through accounts of the complex interactions between spatial scales produced by geographers such as Doreen Massey (1984), Peter Taylor (1982) and Neil Smith (1984).

In light of, and contributing to, these conceptual developments, rural studies of the late 1970s and 1980s was characterised by

[2] Lefebvre does not explicitly address rural space because he is showing 'the universality of the production of a particular kind of space—urban and rural—under capitalism' (Halfacree, 2006: 49). Whereas the outcomes of this production i.e. the 'concrete form' through which this social practice manifests will be differentiated across different socio-spatial contexts, thus "the rural can be a significant category that emerges – and not necessarily just as a dualistic 'response' to the urban – within this differentiation (Halfacree, 2006).

a preoccupation with the (re)constitution of rural space(s) by national and international capital, and within the context of shifting spatial divisions of labour. Proponents of the political-economy perspective focused primarily upon the changing face of agricultural production, and particularly in reference to an apparent shift from Fordist to post-Fordist sets of working relations in the countryside (for example Kenney et al., 1989; Newby, 1978). A growing interest in regulation theory (albeit somewhat eclectic and occasionally conceptually inappropriate in its application) has also taken place against the backdrop of the political economy of the countryside. Taken as a whole, this perspective has sought to better understand the 'regularization or normalization of the economy in its broadest sense, beginning from the insight that continued capital accumulation depends on a series of cultural and political supports' (Goodwin, 2005, p. 305). On this pretext, scholars have undertaken to explore the ways in which the norms of production and consumption which distinguish and inform rurality are embedded in social and cultural exchange (Banks and Marsden, 1997; Cloke and Goodwin, 1992; Marsden, 1992; Pemberton and Goodwin, 2010).

A key text in rural studies to bring a burgeoning relational perspective to political-economy debates was Marsden et al.'s *Constructing the Countryside* (1993), which related wider developments in the global political economy with the behaviour of locally embedded actors. In examining the postwar decline of agricultural productivism and its corporatist structures, Marsden et al. consider how subsequent place-based negotiations of globalization tendencies have led to 'the emergence of a more differentiated countryside…'

> …One whose trajectory is no longer determined to the same degree by the fortunes of a single industry but a more complex assemblage of economic, social and political elements. These elements may be present at the local, regional, national or international scales, but will give individual rural areas quite different complexions. (p. 186; see also Marsden, 1998)

Indeed, Marsden et al. suggest how these post-productivist transitions may be highly contested and locally variable, with outcomes 'dependent upon the local and regional contexts, and the particular situated practice of actor-networks operating within them' (p. 190). Drawing here on Callon (1985), and in corrective to structurally determined accounts of economic change, they advocate following actors and their interests as they meet and intersect with others (social *and* natural) in place; with the resulting relations of power (economic, political and/or cultural) shaping the character and meaning of the 'local' and the 'rural'.

What Marsden et al. term a 'holistic' approach to analysing power relations might thus be considered as a move towards developing a relational rural epistemology, in that it 'explicitly links knowledge (the discursive capacity to formulate interests), social action (the opportunity to act on such formulations) and materiality (the distribution of economic resources that facilitate certain courses of actions)' (p. 140). However, as Halfacree (2006) has noted, Marsden et al.'s differentiated countryside model is 'very much an incremental expression of rural change' (p. 56), presenting a limited trajectory of rural futures when compared to the current ontological emphasis on space (and place) as open, continuous and dynamic, 'always in process … never a closed system' (Massey, 2005, p. 11). Both Halfacree (2006) and Murdoch (2003, 2006) would subsequently re-engage with ideas of the 'differentiated countryside' through the lens of different strands of post-structuralist theory – Halfacree through Lefebvrian notions of the production of space, and Murdoch via a network sociology developed from Deleuze and Latour, amongst others. In so doing, they illustrate two related conceptual pathways through which relational/hybrid accounts of the post-rural are being produced (Cloke, 2006; Woods, 2009a).

3. Post-rural geographies

The emerging focus on relations rather than structures evident in Marsden et al. (1993) was to be expressed more explicitly with the increasing influence of postmodernist/poststructuralist theory on human geography and the social sciences. Evident in rural studies from the early 1990s onwards (e.g. Murdoch and Pratt, 1993; Murdoch and Pratt, 1994; Philo, 1993), this movement brought with it a very clear condemnation of social scientists' capacity for—and the political implications of—determining how the (rural) world is and operates through reference to broad theoretical claims. A criticism which was levelled at the particularly positivist rural studies of the 1950s and 1960s, it was also directed at the at those contributions preceding from structural Marxism, political economy and (to a lesser extent) regulation approaches (Phillips, 1998, p. 42) on the grounds that they have the inclination to overlook everyday, 'messy' accounts of social life which do not necessarily fit into models of either-or.

In rural studies as in social sciences more broadly, the influence of poststructuralist theory has led to a focus on social constructionism and engagement with plural and multiple forms of situated knowledge, meaning and identity. Deconstructing the negotiation of common knowledge through social relations, this form of enquiry is explicitly concerned with 'who makes the rules' and 'for whom', and with the power relations made by, and inherent in the making of, world views (Kukla, 2000). By extension, a significant element of this project is consideration of those who are set outside of mainstream spaces, and a corresponding interest in processes of marginalisation and resistance. This is demonstrated in a swathe of work on 'rural others' (Philo, 1992), wherein the playing out of difference, disparity and disregard has been examined in studies of, among other groups, gay lives in the countryside and the experiences of ethnic minorities in rural space (e.g. Kinsman, 1995; Milbourne, 1997; Smith and Holt, 2005).[3]

As well as highlighting new subjects of research, the uptake of poststructuralist theory in the social sciences prompted conceptual inquiries regarding the nature of space itself. Theorists such as Latour, Deleuze and Serres encouraged the displacement of topographical with topological ways of thinking about the heterogeneity of sociospatial relations that make up the world. Subsequent arguments for 'geographies of becoming' have sought to recognise the practised and performative constitution of space and place, such that they are always open to possibility rather than fixed and contained (Doel, 1999; Massey, 2005; Thrift, 1997, 2004, 2007). 'Thinking space relationally' (Geografiska Annaler, 2004) thus inherently involves thinking about the relations between different material things 'thrown together' in its constitution, and has proceeded alongside various calls for the rematerialization of social and cultural geography (e.g. Jackson, 2000; Lees, 2002; Anderson and Wylie, 2009; Whatmore, 2006). In theorizations of rural

[3] The 'cultural turn' in rural studies is not and should not be taken as being indicative of a downplaying of the role of the 'economy' in making and shaping rural space. Nevertheless, the intellectual ascendency of cultural approaches in rural studies has been linked to an evident ambivalence towards, if not an outright rejection of, political economy approaches among European scholars in particular. At the same time, Buttel has argued that the thrust of cultural-turn rural studies has been 'less to resurrect rural sociological voluntarism or contest the notion that power relations are central to understanding the character of rural and agri-food systems than to add new tools to the analysis of rural power relations' (2001, p. 72). Examples given include Whatmore's reflections on the politicization and symbolization of contemporary food systems (1994).

space, the complex relations between 'natural' and 'social' entities have become of key concern, and the ways in which these flow and are 'mixed up' through rural processes and events (Murdoch, 2003). Here the inability of social constructionist perspectives to apprehend these interrelations has been exposed: 'There is something beyond the 'social' at work as the countryside displays a material complexity that is not easily reducible to even the most nuanced social categories' (Murdoch, 2003: 264).

This understanding led rural studies scholars, most notably Jonathan Murdoch, to engage with repertoires of hybridity and develop conceptualisations of the rural as a 'hybrid and networked space' (Woods, 2009a) and, as previously noted, Bruno Latour's 'actor-network theory' (1993, 2005) has been particularly influential in understanding the composition of rural space through hybrid assemblages of human and non-human actants including biological organisms and technologies (Cloke and Perkins, 2005; Enticott, 2001; Jones, 2006; Murdoch, 1997, 2000, 2003; Rudy, 2005; Whatmore, 2002; Woods, 1998). This ongoing re-thinking of rural human–non-human relations can crucially contribute to our understandings of and responses to global environmental challenges including anthropogenic climate change and food security (Woods, 2011b).

However, whilst the equalisation of relations between all actors and entities in ANT collapses nature-society divides, it has drawn criticism, firstly, for its capacity to grapple with conditions of the moment (Thrift, 2007), and, second, for masking relations of power (Allen, 2003; Jones, 2003). On this first point, Thrift has been led to comment that for all its commitment to the idiosyncrasies of place and the unpredictability of circumstances, 'there is a sense in which actor-network theory is much more able to describe steely accumulation than lightning strikes' (2007, p. 11). Taking issue with the attenuated status of the event within the wider gamut of studies rooted in ANT, but at the same time sympathetic to the language of heterogeneous fragments, flows and assemblages, Thrift has been at the forefront of the development of a 'non-representational theory'. Focusing on the geographies of occasions, sensations and the processes of experience, this manner of thinking has directly influenced a growing number of academics working within the rural sphere (notably Carolan, 2008; Mahon, 2007). These efforts to 'capture bodily actions and impulses, emotions and affective relations' (Thrift, 2007) present ongoing challenges to rural studies scholars, both in terms of apprehending the (re)production of multi-faceted rural space through its everyday socio-economic materialities and in respect to its various representational mobilisations.

On the second point, and in regard to the variable capacities and qualities of different actants (Jones, 2006), this raises ethical issues particularly in relation to animal welfare and rights more explicitly addressed through the 'animal geographies' literature (Philo and Wilbert, 2000; Wolch and Emel, 1998), including studies with a specific 'rural' focus (Evans and Yarwood, 2000; Riley, 2011; Yarwood and Evans, 1998, 1999). Here Jones (2006, p. 283) notes how 'animals are central to how the rural is both materially and imaginatively constructed', with, for example, their enrolment in pro- and anti-hunting discourses (Milbourne, 2003; Woods, 1998, 2000). Thus, while there may be a multitude of things beyond the 'social' at work in relationally constituting rural space, there are also overtly social ways of relating and ordering those heterogeneous elements occurring. This point, and with it the limitations of actor-network perspectives, are similarly recognised by Murdoch (2003) who suggests relational thinking should not be seen as an epistemic shift away from social constructionism, but rather advocates 'theoretical pluralism' in constructing more complex and multi-faceted accounts of the changing countryside.

This recognition of the ongoing validity of social constructionist perspectives might seem contradictory given the turn to bodily practice in human geography emerged, in part, from critiques of the social construction perspective which had dominated large swathes of the discipline following the 'cultural turn'. Certainly, social constructionism's preoccupation with 'immanent processes, the constitution of intersubjective meanings and the outworking of identity politics through texts, signs, symbols and emotions' (Cloke, 2006, p. 22) was arguably undertaken to the neglect of the lived, emergent materialities of everyday life. However, growing critical awareness of the importance of performance, practise and materiality has not served to negate, or even diminish, scholarly interest in the social construction of rural space; which is of timely and critical relevance to contemporary discussions of rurality within globalised contexts. Here the meaning and function of rural space is implicated in some of the major issues facing governments and citizens around the world – food production, supply and security; access and control of energy resources; the development of renewable technologies; and climate change planning and responsiveness (Marsden, 2007; Verburg et al., 2010; Woods, 2011b).

A complementary argument for bringing together material and ideational facets of the rural in order to more fully explore its relationality is made by Keith Halfacree (2006), although drawing instead on Henri Lefebvre and, following him, David Harvey's take on relational space. Indeed, Harvey (1996) has been particularly influential for thinking about the formation of specific (rural) places/localities within contemporary capitalist spatiality (see Liepins, 2000); what he describes as the 'carving of relative permanences from the flow of diverse processes (social, cultural, physical, biological) creating spaces' (Harvey, 1996, p. 261). Thus for Halfacree, rural space 'suggests one of the productive permanences of capitalist spatiality' (2006, p. 50), yet in order to avoid rural fetishism it is essential to appreciate how the multi-faceted character of this 'permanence' comes into being, and how it is continuously challenged and remade. Here Halfacree turns to Lefebvre and his 'conceptual triad' of spatiality to propose not a new theory but a complex model of rural space, drawing together theoretical and methodological insights from the rural studies corpus to identify three dynamically entwined facets which together comprise rural space as a totality. As Woods (2011a, p. 292) expounds:

> The portal of '*rural locality*' allows us to glimpse the structural patterns produced by specific configurations of larger social and economic processes; the portal of '*representations of the rural*' provides sight of the discursive meanings applied to the rural in relation to the wider world; and the portal of '*everyday lives of the rural*' illuminates the routine enactment of a relational rural by individuals whose mobility is not constrained to rural space. (Added emphasis)

Both Halfacree and Murdoch bring these relational epistemologies to bear in considering the production of heterogeneity in the post-productivist countryside and, building on Marsden et al., suggest more extensive and open 'rural futures'. For Halfacree (2006), it is through everyday lives and practices that the material and ideational/symbolic elements of the rural are brought together, and wherein lies the potential for more radical rural spatialities to be imagined – and made lasting (see also Bell et al., 2010). Similarly for Murdoch (2003, 2006), the 'differentiated countryside' is a space of increasing complexity and hybridity, as the proliferation of heterogeneous networks—both part of, and resulting, from globalization processes and trends—work to displace longstanding (national) socio-economic structures (Urry, 2000) and give rise to new social, political and economic interrelations and dependencies across rural 'regions'.

These two connected strands—the transformation of the rural under contemporary globalization and a contested 'politics of the rural'—represent some of the major arenas through which 'the rural is being re-made as a multi-authored, multi-faceted and co-constituted space' (Woods, 2011a, p. 265). Together with a renewed concern with rural-urban relations (see McCarthy, 2008; Woods, 2009a), they provide a focus for ongoing rural studies research, which, as we've thus far argued, has sought to consolidate 'new' and 'old' theoretical perspectives so as to better apprehend the rural as a hybrid, relational space.

4. Relational theories for relational times

As suggested, the enduring co-constitutive relationship between the urban and rural has received renewed attention in light of relational approaches. Woods (2011a, p. 43) notes how 'the rural has always been defined and imagined in relational terms, as relative to urban space and society' (and see Carmo, 2009). However, he observes how accounting for the actual material relations (social and economic) which exist across and between this discursive divide has proved problematic for both political-economy and social constructionist conceptualisations of rurality (e.g. Hoggart, 1990). Whereas, a relational approach provides the theoretical means to develop this analysis, by permitting 'us to recognise the diverse networks and flows that criss-cross rural and urban space and the hybrid forms that result as being part of the very constitution of both the rural and the urban' (p. 43).

Both McCarthy (2008) and Woods (2009a) respectively take stock of recent empirical research concerned with the spatial entanglement of rural and urban identities; where global flows of actors, finance, commodities, cultural imaginaries and practices are variously brought together in processes including suburban growth and expansion (Álvarez-Rivadulla, 2007; Davis, 2006; Leichenko and Solecki, 2005; Tan et al., 2005) amenity migration to rural areas (Darling, 2005; Gogia, 2006; Gosnell and Abrams, 2011; Moss, 2006; Perkins, 2006; Woods, 2009b) and the less considered 'ruralization' of the city (Lacour and Puissant, 2007; Urbain, 2002). Further, studies have considered how rural and urban distinctions (as both materially and discursively drawn) are being blurred by the hybrid sociospatial forms produced through these processes. These include peri-urban communities (Bossuet, 2006), the rural–urban fringe (Gallent and Andersson, 2007; Mahon, 2007) and 'exurbia', with the latter term deployed notably in the North American context in relation to communities outside a town or city's suburbs being transformed by in-migration (Cadieux and Hurley, 2009 Larsen et al., 2007; Taylor, 2011; Walker, 2011). The ways in which this 'blurring' is being made sense of through the 'everyday lives of the rural' has further been explored, in terms of the negotiation and contestation of place-based identities (Larsen and Hutton, 2011; Mahon, 2007) and their enrolment in conflicts over land use and competing interests (Cadieux, 2009; Mahon et al., 2009; Masuda and Garvin, 2008; Walker and Fortmann, 2003).

McCarthy (2008) suggests the theorisation of these ongoing trends forms part of 'a larger conversation about the effects of globalization on rural areas' (p. 130). And indeed, Murdoch (2006) has noted how the urban-focus prevalent in network society accounts of global-local hybridity (e.g. Castells, 1996) and its apogee the 'global city' (Sassen, 1991) has meant that, by comparison, the differential impacts of globalization processes across rural localities have received limited consideration (see also Hogan, 2004). Generalist accounts of globalization emphasise the inculcation of rural localities into global networks of capital, leading to their material exploitation as well as threatening distinctive rural cultures, with local actors posited as reactionary agents. Whereas, research explicitly concerned with globalization impacts on rural contexts, coming from a range of disciplinary perspectives, has tended to focus on broad economic trends rather than contextual specificity (but see Bebbington, 2001 and Echánove, 2005). Such trends include commodity chains and the global agri-food system, rural economic restructuring, rural development, depeasantization, migration flows and rural policy reforms (see Woods, 2007 for a comprehensive overview of these literatures). Murdoch's invocation to address this oversight by investigating 'the means by which differing mixtures of networks are put in (rural) *place*' (2006, p. 181, added emphasis) is consequently starting to be taken up. Young (2006), for example, draws together actor-network and political economy perspectives in considering distance a 'hybrid actor' and key source of power and spatial variance in diversifying rural economies. Whilst Woods (2007), in a more broadly-targeted intervention, proposes a heuristic framework for the place-based study of globalization processes, with his model of the 'Global Countryside'.

Woods (2007) employs a relational understanding of globalization as developed by Doreen Massey (see Massey, 2005), who herself draws on the geo-philosophy of Gilles Deleuze in order to provide a link between concepts of networked relationality and territory. Massey then, understands places as the 'meeting-points' of multiple flows and networks that constitute global 'power-geometries':

> 'Places' are criss-crossings in the wider power-geometries that constitute both themselves and 'the global'. On this view local places are not simply always the victims of the global; nor are they always politically defensible redoubts against the global. Understanding space as the constant open production of the topologies of power points to the fact that different 'places' will stand in contrasting relations to the global. (Massey, 2005, p. 101)

Understanding these place-specific 'relations to the global' requires, on the one hand, paying attention to the agency of local actors, whilst also examining the broader economic and political relations—both historical and contemporary—which locate places within wider networks. Applying this to rural contexts, Woods (2007) introduces the 'global countryside' as a hypothetical space representing the ultimate outcomes of globalization processes. This space is yet to be fully attained, but shown to be partially articulated to greater/lesser degrees in different rural localities based on 'locally specific engagements with and responses to globalization' (p. 486) involving both human and non-human actors. The outcome of this perspective is that:

> Globalization cannot be reduced to the subordination of the local by global forces; nor the power of the global to domination. Rather, the impact of globalization in reshaping rural places is manifest through processes of negotiation, manipulation and hybridization, contingent on the mobilization of associational power, and conducted through but not constrained by local micro-politics. (Woods, 2007, p. 502)

Responding to and methodologically engaging Woods' (2007) well-considered call for a 'new, multidimensional research agenda that emphasizes the importance of place-based research' (Woods, 2007) for rural studies (and beyond) is a point to which we will return in the following section. At the same time, localised resistance to globalization processes in both the global north and the global south has become a prominent feature of contestations over the meaning and use of rural space and, as such, a significant focus for research concerned with the relational entanglement of networks, processes and actors involved in its everyday reproduction.

This was evident with a 2008 special issue of the *Journal of Rural Studies* on the topic of Social Movements and Rural Politics (and see also Halhead, 2006; Moyo and Yeros, 2005; Stahler-Sholk et al., 2007; Wolford, 2004), with papers examining diverse examples of rural political mobilisations including the international farmers' coalition La Via Campesina (Desmarais, 2008), land reclamation movements in Brazil (Caldeira, 2008), place-based opposition to timber harvesting in Canada (Larsen, 2008) and the plurality of ideologically diverse social movements in rural England (Reed, 2008). Varying in scale from local and nationally-based coalitions to transnational advocacy networks, these examples are suggestive of a broader shift away from hierarchical political organizations to more fluid social movement networks characterised by more informal modes of belonging focused on shared concerns about diverse issues and identity politics.

Referring specifically to the rural context in the global north, Woods (2003, 2008) relates this shift in political form to the decline of productivist agriculture and its associated power structures, whose interests had long dominated rural policy discourse (see also Mormont, 1987). In its stead, the 'politics of the rural' has come to be characterised by multiple struggles over the meaning and regulation of the rural itself, with coalition building between localised protest groups leading to the formation of a broader 'rural identity movement… framed around the notion of an urban–rural divide and a perceived neglect or marginalisation of rural interests' (Woods, 2008, p. 131). Rural social movements in the global south may well share similar concerns, yet they have also developed in response to the particular historical context of 'postcolonialism, underdevelopment and extreme social and economic inequality' (p. 132) leading to a focus on issues of land reform and protecting peasant agricultural practice against neoliberal reform (Moyo and Yeros, 2005; Routledge, 2003).

Even as coalitions such as La Via Campesina seek to coordinate the actions of small and medium-scale agricultural producers around the world in response to the perceived unifying force of neoliberal globalization, there is nonetheless tremendous diversity in terms of the global/local identity and interests of various rural social movements. For Bell et al. (2010, p. 220), the politics of the rural are thus 'polymorphous, polysemous and polyvocal, making the rural hard to pin down'. For example, they note the increasing support (financial and ideological) given to international farmers' organisations from urban and non-farm residents. The power of these organisations is therefore, in Bell, Lloyd and Vatovec's terms, a relational consequence of both *materially* manifested 'rural constituencies' (i.e. farming communities residing in rural localities) and *symbolically* bounded 'constituencies of the rural' (i.e. advocates of organic agriculture) who together may become effective forces in the 'active politics of the rural'. Counter to notions of 'rural passivity and death' as arguably reproduced by the social sciences' 'mobilities turn' and, with it, an emphasis on 'urban strength and vitality' (p. 206), the politics of the rural (whether progressive or otherwise) is recognised to involve active processes of 'mobilising and stabilising the material, the symbolic and the relational' (p. 221). For example, the power of food sovereignty depends on the claim that a globally exported product comes from a material rural location and hence the symbolic mobilisation of this 'stability' through wine bottle labelling bearing protected geographical indicators, or how more mobile ways of living may be facilitated by the consumption of a spatially and temporally located notion of rurality through second-home purchase (Halfacree, 2011).

Recognising the active politics of the rural as such would appear to contradict Doreen Massey's (2005) claim that through representation and spatial ordering (contra relational understandings) 'the very life, and certainly the politics, are taken out of [space]' (p. 30). While we certainly agree with the former part of her argument, which, as demonstrated, has been taken up in efforts to rematerialize rural studies through an emphasis on lived social relations and modes of being/becoming, the latter is perhaps more questionable. For as Miller (2006, p. 464) has argued 'representation is really the point at which politics is put into space' and here the adjective is of fundamental importance, as it is through the active practice of representing (and therefore stabilising through closure) that power relations are enacted. By paying attention to the relational intertwining of the material and the representational/symbolic *through practice* (Halfacree, 2006) rural scholars are finding ways of 'repoliticizing rural studies without sacrificing the insights available from cultural approaches' (Cloke, 2006, p. 26).

5. Minor theory and countertopography

Rather than simply *thinking* (rural) space relationally then, we have argued rural studies approaches need to *be* epistemologically relational in terms of developing what Cloke (2006) terms 'hybridized theory' and Murdoch (2006) 'theoretical pluralism'. That is, to consider the value of existing theoretical resources (social constructionism, political and economic materialism) in relation with the critical and rigorous appraisal of 'new' concepts and ideas so that we might better comprehend and convey the relations of interconnection which constitute rural space in its multidimensional complexity *and* particularity. In this vein, Cloke suggests a way forward in conceptualising rurality might involve closer engagement with what geographer Cindi Katz (1996) termed 'minor theory': 'That is, doing theory in a rather different register which disrupts binary relations between the theoretical and the empirical, which is far less totalizing, less judgemental, less certain, more fluid' (2006, p. 26). Through denying the capacity of any one critical perspective to adequately portray spatial complexity, and rejecting the premise that any one methodology can sufficiently unpack this complexity, minor theory is intent on changing theory and practice simultaneously and in a way that can be 'conjoined with the critical and transformative concerns of Marxism, feminism, antiracism, and queer theory', and in a form that can 'pry apart conventional geographies and produce renegade cartographies of change' (Katz, 1996, p. 487).

Katz's own prescription for this critical transformation, and one in which we also see much value, is through what she refers to as topographical analysis, and the political exercise of constructing 'countertopographies' (2001). In this section we will briefly argue for the potential of countertopography as a further mode of theory and practice for rural studies scholarship; beginning with Katz's own development of the concept and its subsequent applications in predominantly feminist scholarship, before demonstrating the value of this approach for developing relational *and* contextual understandings of the emergent global countryside linking local and global scales.

In its traditional usage topography is a means of accurately describing and delineating a given locality in regards to its material features and resources. Stemming from a concern to reinvigorate the material in feminist theory, Katz (2001) loosely draws upon this topographical understanding of how the sedimentary overlaying of historical processes creates conditions of similarity and difference in order to develop the metaphor of a *critical topography*; concerned with 'excavating the layers of process that produce particular places and to see the intersections with material social practises at other scales of analysis' (Katz, 2001, p. 1228). Through revealing the embeddedness of these practises, the trajectories of socio-political difference and inequality brought about through globalization become apparent; as do the common experiences of capitalism as capital, labour and cultural products move between materially situated locales. Using the metaphor of 'contour lines', Katz

maintains that translocal forms and practises can be traced, and the reasons underpinning their mobility accounted for. This involves the analytical task of constructing a *countertopography*:

> Contour lines are lines of constant elevation, connecting places at precisely the same altitude to reveal a terrain's three-dimensional shape. I want to imagine a politics that maintains the distinctiveness of a place while recognising that it is connected analytically to other places along contour lines that represent not elevation but particular relations to a process (e.g. globalizing capitalist relations of production). This offers a multi-faceted way of theorizing the connectedness of vastly different places made artificially discrete by virtue of history and geography but which also which reproduce themselves differently amidst the common political-economic and socio-cultural processes they experience. (Katz, 2001, p. 1229).[4]

A feminist countertopography reads connections and commonality against hegemonic (top-down) topographies of global capitalism and power (Pratt, 2004); seeking to reveal the embodied geographies of the subaltern and marginalized which are *not* generalizable under abstract terms such as globalization, but involve specific and intricate power relations that construct mutual geographies of disadvantage. In her own writing, Katz exemplifies this process by drawing parallels between the global and local forces affecting childrens' lives in Harlem, New York, and in the Sudanese agricultural community of Howa during the 1980s[5]; destabilizing entrenched North/South binaries (Martin, 2005). To date, the impact of countertopography has similarly been most evident within feminist (geo)political and development geographies, where a principle concern has been to develop modes of investigation and analysis which better appreciate, unravel and populate the socio-economic materialities of the global north and south in tandem (Martin, 2005; McIlwaine and Datta, 2003; Nagar et al., 2002), and specifically through the (mobile and immobile) bodies of those 'at the 'sharp end' of various forms of international activity, from trade to development to warfare' (Dixon, 2011: 71; and see Mountz and Hyndman, 2006; Mountz, 2011; Rossiter and Wood, 2005; Sharp, 2007; Staeheli and Nagel, 2006).

These and further studies, such as Freeman's (2004) examination of the re-location of Moroccan women's identities within increasingly transnational cultural and economic flows, or Oberhauser and Pratt's (2004) account of the changing political-economic strategies employed by women in rural South Africa, draw attention to the interconnectivity of political-economic scales to reveal 'a local that is constitutively global' (Katz, 2001: 1214). It is also clear how Katz's ideas have been influential within political and economic geography more broadly, with the 'modesty' of her minor theory proving compatible with a range of theoretical positions and methodological imperatives. Notably, Eric Sheppard (2002) has cited countertopography in his challenge to the simplicity of pro- and anti-globalization narratives, as do Leitner and Miller (2007), Sparke (2004) and Routledge (2008); all of whom take issue with the conceptualisation of globalization as an all-pervasive, homogenous causal force. As a mode of theory and practice, topography is therefore a way of grappling with globalization beyond-situ, suggesting many potential entry points and intersections between a countertopographical mode of analysis and the contemporary concerns of rural studies scholarship with rural/urban and local/global co-constitutive relations as previously outlined. Certainly, inroads have already been made in this regard in the form of studies centred on rural transformations in the global south (including Freeman, 2004; Oberhauser and Pratt, 2004), and there is much scope then to investigate the re-making of rural communities along these lines in the global north in relation to ongoing processes of socio-economic change and restructuring.

Indeed, for us a specific application of (counter) topographical analysis would be to the practical interrogation of the emergent 'global countryside' (Woods, 2007); with both approaches sharing a commensurate refusal to frame local places simply as victims of global change (Nagar et al., 2002) and insisting instead on careful examination of the situated and practiced connections between the global and the local. This point of common concern can be further expounded along the following three lines: First, both approaches cast space as the variable condition brought forth through uneven reconfigurations of social and economic reproduction, and, as such, make much of the processes which transform everyday lives in disparate geographical settings; be they working to fashion 'urban' spaces, 'rural' spaces, or both. Second, and related, countertopography and the premise of the 'global countryside' are also determinedly sensitive to the balance of negotiations between global forces and local actors, with both drawing attention to the prospect of communities actively resisting, disrupting and remodelling unfavourable relations of power. Third, and in practise, the emphasis that Woods (2007) gives to multidimensional and place-based research resonates with Katz's use of 'thick' historiographical descriptions of social relations, material practises and the production of meaning in landscape.

The European Seventh Framework project 'DERREG' (Developing Europe's Rural Regions in the Era of Globalisation)—on which one of us (Laura) has worked—takes Woods' global countryside model as the theoretical starting point for the place-based analysis of globalization processes across rural regions in eight European countries, and provides an example of where elements of countertopographical analysis have been pursued and could be further extended. Here research has stemmed from the understanding that, while encounters with globalization are transforming rural places, they are not simply becoming homogenized as an outcome; variously bringing advantage and opportunities for development, but also producing new inequalities as a consequence (McDonagh et al., in press). One strand of this research has specifically considered how the increased ease of transnational mobility (for some) is materially impacting on rural places in both similar and different ways, through focusing analysis on the experiences and motivations of three types of rural migrants: migrant workers, foreign home-owners and return transnational migrants.

Here connections, or contour lines, can be traced between geographically distant places experiencing similar processes, such as recent waves of return migration to Ireland's West Region and to Alytus county in Lithuania. In-depth biographical interviews with these return migrants, however, began to reveal different accounts of the relations entered into and practiced whilst away from their home country (e.g. jobs, social networks, dealing with bureaucracy), as well as those relations maintained in a different form

[4] It is important to note that the associations which a countertopography is built upon take the form of 'precise analytic relationships', as opposed to homogenizations, and that the overall objective of countertopographies is to derive an oppositional politics from materially situated knowledges. Countertopography is also, however, set in contrast to 'situatedness', which is concept criticised by Katz for three reasons: First, that through positioning the subject in (as opposed to through) the landscape, it 'collapses dimensionality': Second, Katz is critical of situatedness for the reason that it alludes to somewhere, but to no place in particular: Third, if everything is taken to be situated and specific, the politics of extension and translation is too readily assumed and seldom adequately identified.

[5] Focusing on the social disinvestments brought about by the loss of manufacturing jobs in the former, and the implication of 'development' policies in the latter, effectively served to undermine the skills and knowledge base of younger people in both places. As a result, Katz is led to reflect on how the greatly reduced guarantee of meaningful work has effectively condemned large numbers of young Americans to prison, and a growing number of Sudanese teenagers to the ranks of militias.

(e.g. letters or emails to family back home) or else stretched to breaking point, and how these intersect with political-economic materialities on their return. For example, rural development discourses identify the potential contribution of return migrants to rural communities and economies, drawing on skills and competences developed 'elsewhere'. Whilst this held true for the majority of return migrants to the West Region, with one interviewee for instance noting how training and skills obtained whilst in Boston had allowed them to establish a successful plumbing business (in addition to farming) upon returning to Ireland, another individual returning to Lithuania also from the United States reflected on how a lack of locally embedded knowledge as a result of their corporeal mobility was a potential hindrance: "The knowledge that emigrants accumulate abroad about business and similar is not always applicable – return migrants don't know many peculiarities and circumstances related to the situation in Lithuania" (cited in Frys and Nienaber, 2011).

In this way, a countertopographical analysis foregrounds the everyday process of how and with what effect the positionality of being a return-migrant (or other form of migrant) is relationally produced and also maintained in different ways after the migration event, as opposed to simply being the finished outcome and end-point of national and supra-national forces. Whilst highlighting an emergent politics of 'location and differentation' (Mountz, 2011), these brief quotes begin to reveal interesting narratives around issues of returning 'home' and how different migrants account for and maintain (or not) connections between multiple homes or places of dwelling (see Staeheli and Nagel, 2006), as well as potential conflicts that arise around the materialisation of different knowledges, expectations and imaginaries of (rural) place (Ní Laoire, 2007). Here then, and more broadly, it becomes apparent how globalization is constituted by embodied social relations of 'mobility, emotion, materiality, belonging and alienation' (Mountz and Hyndman, 2006, p. 447) that are intrinsically bound up with discursive and representational practices, and which together inform the ongoing negotiation and re-making of rural and urban spaces(s)—amongst a host of other socio-spatial contexts—concomitantly.

6. Concluding remarks

As should by now be clear, our arguments are not intended to infer that rural studies is—or has ever been—in need of playing theoretical catch-up with 'urban', 'political' or 'cultural' geography, or any other crudely delineated (sub)discipline (see also Jackson, 2005). Rather, we have sought to chart how the move to conceptualising spatiality in relational terms has unfolded in rural studies in particular ways. Accordingly, this paper is not intended as a call for rural studies to uncritically embrace the latest theoretical zeitgeist and, in so doing, necessitate 'the laying down of previous ideas in order to adopt new ones' (Cloke, 2006, p. 26). For whilst the turn to 'thinking space relationally' has initiated more open, contingent and actor-driven accounts of social life across the social sciences broadly, it has not progressed without critique (Dainton, 2001; Harrison, 2006; Jones, 2009, 2010; Sunley, 2008). For instance, Jones (2009, 2010) notes how, in emphasising the openness and potential of space above all else, the specifics of the relations under discussion have often been underdeveloped. That is, without specifying the distinctive ways in which certain spatially related things are connected, Jones (2010) suggests how, citing Harvey (1996), 'the reduction of everything to fluxes and flows…. says nothing about nothing' (p. 249). At the same time, relational thinking can overlook how sociospatial relations of (relative) permanence are reproduced and sustained (cf. Harvey, 1996), and the ways in which these material and discursive permanences *matter* in people's everyday lives.

In keeping with this criticism, and sensitive to Woods' call for greater consideration of 'locally specific engagements with and responses to globalization' (2007, p. 486), we have proposed countertopography as a valuable conceptual and methodological addition to rural studies already rich analytical 'toolkit', and one which is inherently 'relational' insofar as it considers the playing out of processes which are specific to particular places and communities and constitutive of difference, but also those processes which unravel in similar ways across broader socio-material contours. In so doing, it intermeshes the 'politics of the rural' and a broader politics of global inequality, and points towards the important contribution a *critically* relational rural studies can make to understanding and shaping our 'constitutively interrelated' global present, and futures (Massey, 2005).

Acknowledgements

The authors are grateful to the editor and to the two anonymous referees for their encouragement and helpful comments on an earlier version of this paper.

This publication is based on research supported by the Wales Institute of Social & Economic Research, Data & Methods (WISERD), which is funded by the UK Economic & Social Research Council (ESRC) (grant number: RES-576-25-0021) and the Higher Education Funding Council for Wales (HEFCW). This paper also draws on research undertaken as part of the 'DERREG' project (*Developing Europe's Rural Regions in the Era of Globalization*), funded by the European Union Framework Programme 7 (grant number: 225204), and the authors would like to acknowledge the contribution of all of the DERREG project partners for helping to shape many of the ideas presented in this paper.

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